Wherever possible I have illustrated my text with black and white drawings and early photographs from yesterday's India. Every effort has been made to obtain clearance for their use, although in some cases it has not been possible to locate a presumed copyright holder. All who supplied photographs or helped me with information and support have, I hope, been named and thanked in my Acknowledgements and Picture Credits. All uncredited contemporary photographs were taken either by me or by my wife, Liz Allen.

The names of many people and places mentioned come in different forms and spellings according to source and language used. For example, the town in Tamil Nadu known as Trichy to the British, and as Trichinopoly to Sanskrit-based language speakers, is better known to Tamil-speakers as Tiruchirappalli (or variations in spelling thereof). Here I am sticking to the best-known version (in this case, Trichy), with the local spelling added in brackets where appropriate.

I have tried wherever possible to avoid that loaded word 'Aryan', with all its negative connotations. The original Vedic term was 'Arya' and I am sticking with that in reference to the Sanskrit-speakers whose distinctive culture first emerged in Northern India about three and a half thousand years ago. Their word for their priestly caste was *Brahmana*. This was shortened to *Brahman* and then anglicised into Brahmin, which is just plain wrong. Even so, Brahmin is now common usage so Brahmin it is here.

The word 'Sanskritist' also requires clarification. In academic terms, a Sanskritist is not simply someone who knows all the *Shastras* by heart but a scholar who studies them as a philologist trained in the structure of language. So Panini, the scholar credited with assembling the first Sanskrit grammar, *Ashtadhyayi*, could be said to be the first Sanskritist, but not the Brahmin priests who assisted him. Similarly, the great philologist Sir William Jones became in time a Sanskritist but, arguably, not so his chief pandit